princely states, which had not yet been fully integrated into the Indian Union? Neither description would have been correct in the 1960s. But Sikkim was indeed once an independent kingdom and much larger than it is today. The area was settled in the thirteenth century by Tibetan herdsmen and swidden-cultivating Lepchas, but it was not until the seventeenth century that it came to resemble a state with its own administration. The first ruler is believed to have been Phuntsog Namgyal, who, in 1642, was consecrated as the first *chogyal* (king) of Sikkim. His ancestors came from Kham in eastern Tibet. Along with his lamas, Phuntsog converted the Lepcha people to Buddhism. He appointed 12 ministers to his government, all of whom came from the Tibetan-related Bhutia community, and another 12 men from the Lepchas were made heads in the same number of newly created, local administrative units. He also founded the Namgyal Dynasty, which continued to rule the country into modern times.

Some modern Tibetologists have questioned this official history, arguing that Phuntsog and his successors ruled over a much more loosely constructed entity, and that it was British expansion into the Himalayas in the early nineteenth century (and thus a foreign threat to Sikkim's sovereignty) that led to efforts to re-imagine Sikkimese history in 'an attempt to define Sikkim as a nation'.[6]

Whichever version of Sikkimese history one chooses to believe, Sikkim was a separate kingdom when the British arrived on the scene and it did once include the Chumbi Valley in present-day Tibet. It stretched westward to the Arun River in Nepal and southward to northern West Bengal, although the extent of Sikkimese influence over those areas waxed and waned with advances and retreats resulting from the chogyals' wars against their Nepalese and Bhutanese neighbours. Lots of territory was lost to the Nepalese Gorkha rajahs, but some of it was restored to Sikkim under two treaties signed in 1816 and 1817, the first between the British East India Company and the Nepalese and the other between the British East India Company and the chogyal of Sikkim.

The arrival of the British brought fundamental changes to Sikkim. In 1828, a group of East India Company officials, having settled a conflict between Nepal and Sikkim, found a place in the southern Sikkimese highlands which they deemed suitable for the location of a sanatorium for British servicemen and invalid servants. Seven years later, in 1835, a strip of territory was acquired for that purpose from the ruler of Sikkim, and the